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The COOP takes a page out of its past

After years of struggle, it aims to reinvent itself as a bookstore and something more

By Alexa Gagosz
GLOBE STAFF

For more than a century, the Harvard Cooperative Society, better known as the COOP, was as much part of Harvard Square's intellectual life as the Cambridge universities that surround it. Harvard and MIT students browsed books and vinyl records for hours, purchased a new suit for a big interview, and rubbed shoulders with the likes of Andy Warhol,

Bette Midler, and even Larry Bird.

But over the years, the COOP withered as the world changed around it. Amazon siphoned sales from bookstores everywhere. Digital course materials replaced textbooks. Harvard Square became more expensive, more corporate, and touristy. When the COOP renovated its flagship store in 2021, longtime customers complained it had been reduced to a souvenir shop, trading stacks of literature

for racks of Crimson sweatshirts and lanyards.

Now, a new generation of leaders is trying to make the COOP relevant to a generation that has little reason to visit a bookstore anymore. The organization has ambitious expansion plans, pushing beyond its traditional Harvard Square roots into Kendall Square and Allston, with a new store model built around the kinds of cultural and intellectual experiences that

can't be purchased online.

Its first test case is in Allston, where the COOP recently opened inside the Atlas Hotel on Western Avenue near the Harvard Business School campus.

With movable fixtures, curated books and vinyl, products from emerging student startups out of Harvard, and a space designed for author talks, DJ sets, and chef events, executives describe the

COOP, Page A6

Racial wealth gap persists in Mass.

Black, Latino families have little hope of buying homes

By Katie Johnston, Andrew Brinker, and Mara Kardas-Nelson

GLOBE STAFF

A decade ago, the Federal Reserve Bank of Boston released a shocking study that showed US-born Black Bostonians had a median net worth of just \$8.

The results reverberated widely, although the survey itself had some drawbacks. The Fed has now revisited the subject, but with a more comprehensive analysis that includes the entire state.

And again, the results show a staggering wealth gap.

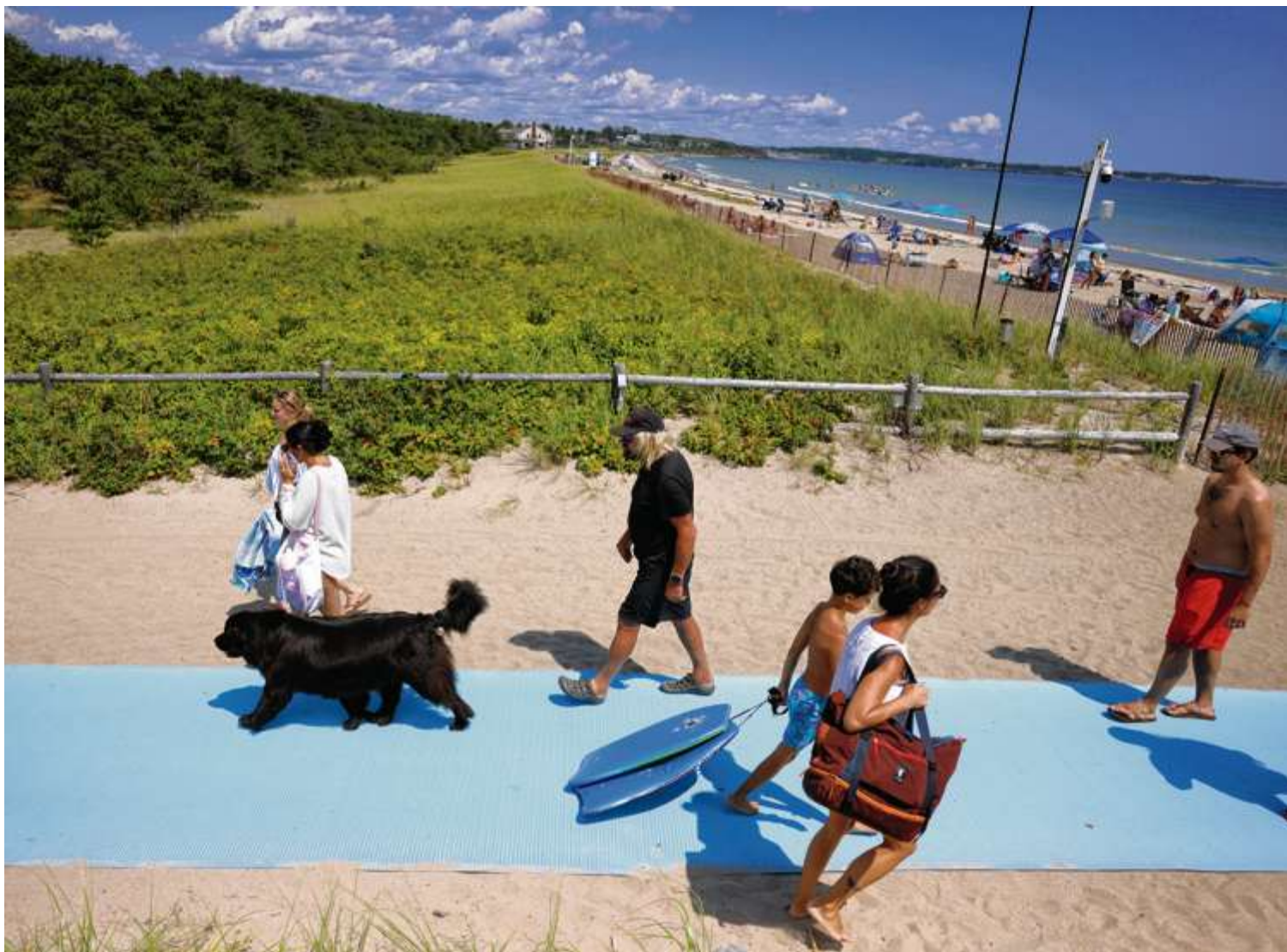
The new report, released Wednesday, found Latino families in Massachusetts have a median net wealth of just \$1,200; Black families have only slightly more, at \$7,800.

White families, on the other hand, have a median net wealth of \$549,200, while Asian American, Native Hawaiian, and Pacific Islander families are at \$305,000.

It also highlighted the power of homeownership in a part of the country where extraordinarily high real estate prices are making the dream of home buying increasingly unattainable, especially among the state's Black and Latino population.

Those racial and ethnic disparities reflect centuries of discrimination in societal norms, financial practices, and public policy that have restricted the accumulation of wealth in Black and Latino households, research shows. Even in Massachu-

WEALTH GAP, Page A10



PHOTOS BY JESSICA RINALDI/GLOBE STAFF

Despite all his best efforts, lifeguard Greg Wilfert (center) had a close call with a shark recently at Scarborough Beach.

Staying on top of the shark problem

Maine beach fights back with drones and other high-tech tools

By Bryan Hecht, Thai Theodoro, and Ariela Lopez

GLOBE CORRESPONDENTS

SCARBOROUGH, Maine — A surge in white shark activity around Maine has closed various swimming areas, but one beach south of Portland is determined to stay open, thanks to some high-tech tools.

At Scarborough Beach, two drones surveil the water, lifeguards use a jet ski to chase away sharks, while others mount an ATV to alert swimmers all along the half-mile length of beach.

Scarborough also has four lifeguard dogs that have been professionally trained to aid in water rescues, though officials said they are temporarily restricted to the beach because of the sudden rise in shark attacks.

"There were sightings in nearby beaches, so we started using our drone protocol more," said Greg Wilfert, a 71-year-old lifeguard who is also head of operations for the beach.

Scarborough Beach, which is owned by the state but managed by a private company of which Wilfert is a partner, is the first beach in New England to employ regular

SHARKS, Page A10



Lifeguard Cam Boone controlled a drone over the beach.



Some

70 percent

of white households

here own their homes,

according to census data,

compared with

39 percent

of Black households and

32 percent

of Latino households.

Experts will have big part in Clancy ruling

By Lea Skene

GLOBE STAFF

This story may contain content readers find disturbing or triggering. For help with postpartum mood disorders, the National Maternal Mental Health Hotline is free, confidential, and 24/7. Text or call 1-833-TLC-MAMA. If you or someone you know is having thoughts of suicide, call 988 or go to 988lifeline.org to chat online.

As the Lindsay Clancy trial draws a large following of armchair observers and becomes the subject of widespread speculation online, the action inside the courtroom is following a specific procedural structure largely unique to insanity cases.

Perhaps the most striking feature of such cases: The facts often aren't in dispute. It's the defendant's mental state the jury will consider — to determine whether she should be held legally responsible for her actions.

Legal analysts expect the testimony will ultimately come to focus heavily on the opinions of expert witnesses, including mental health professionals who have reviewed the evidence available.

"In a mental illness defense case, the role of the experts is much more substantial than in a typical criminal case," said attorney Keith Halp-

TRIAL, Page A7

FRANK SMITH 1924-2026

Forgotten behind bars, he served a term never matched

By Annalisa Quinn

GLOBE STAFF

"Frank Smith Has A Date With Death," read a headline in The Hartford Courant on July 6, 1954. Mr. Smith, then 29, was set to be executed the following day for the murder of a night watchman at a yacht club.

But Mr. Smith instead would go on to become the longest-serving prisoner in the history of the United States. And on June 25, the diminutive man with a wisp of white hair died quietly in bed in a secure nursing home in Rocky Hill, Conn., a few months shy of his 102nd birthday.

In all of those years, Mr. Smith never stopped dreaming about the electric chair at the prison in Wethersfield,

Conn., in whose oak arms he expected to die in 1954.

It was his eighth scheduled execution, after seven stays. He had come to know intimately the pageant of the last meal, the final visit from the chaplain, the long night before in the room next to the execution chamber.

On that eighth and final date, Mr. Smith's head was shaved for the electric chair. But hours before the appointed time, the officer who arrested him burst into a meeting of the Board of Pardons and announced he believed Mr. Smith had not killed Grover Hart, a night watchman at a Greenwich yacht club with a wife and daughter.

Mr. Smith was granted a final re-

SMITH, Page C9

Pool cue

Thursday: Classic summer. High 82-87. Low 66-71.

Friday: More of the same. High 81-86. Low 61-66. High tide: 12:21 p.m.

Sunrise: 5:49 Sunset: 7:48

Weather and Comics, D5-6.

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00



A man died after he was stabbed during the evening rush hour at South Station following a fight on an escalator, Boston police said. **B1.**

An Acton teen who allegedly used AI and the internet to search for "theoretical ideas or fantasy stories" about killing his family was charged with murdering his mother and brother. **B1.**

Boston residents and visitors attending World Cup-related events spent \$83 million in the city and generated \$1.5 million in local tax revenue in the second half of June. **B1.**

The US is on track to pull its forces out of Iraq by the end of September, marking the end of a presence that started in 2003. **A3.**